1958, he is reported to have said in a private conversation with the Indian ambassador-designate to Beijing, G. Parthasarathi,

> I don‘t trust the Chinese one bit. They are a deceitful, opinionated, arrogant and hegemonistic lot. Eternal vigilance should be our watchword. You should send all your telegrams only to me, not to the Foreign Office. Also, do not mention a word of this instruction of mine to Krishna [Menon]. He, you and I all share a common worldview and ideological approach. However, Krishna believes, erroneously, that no Communist country can have bad relations with any Non-Aligned country like ours.[10]

That was Menon’s most serious misjudgement. But as Kaul wrote in his book about the 1962 War and its aftermath, ‘When Menon fell from grace, his many past services to India were forgotten and only his errors remembered’.[11] Menon was in fact one of the most brilliant minds and dynamic personalities ever to have held a ministerial post in the Indian government. He was a vegetarian, did not drink alcohol or smoke tobacco, and, as a minister, he lived in a small room in a modest bungalow full of books.

As a young man in the 1920s and 1930s, Menon had studied at University College, London, and the London School of Economics, where his professor of political science, Harold Laski, later described him as ‘the best student I have ever had’.[12] After independence, Menon became India’s first High Commissioner to the United Kingdom and, later, the Indian ambassador to the UN. He was also one of the brains behind the 1955 Bandung Conference and the creation of the Non-Aligned Movement. In fact, the very term ‘non-aligned’ was coined by Menon in a speech at the UN in New York in 1953 to describe countries which were allied with neither the West nor the Soviet Union. But it was hardly any secret that Menon was more sympathetic to Moscow than to Washington and London.

When he took over the Defence Ministry in 1957, he was ‘like a fresh breath of air, which blew away the cobwebs and layers of dust accumulated on the portfolio over the years’.[13] He was arrogant and not especially liked by his co-workers, whether subordinate or senior to him in the hierarchy, but, according to Kaul, ‘He was a well-read man and an encyclopaedia on practically every subject under the sun such as science, philosophy, medicine, engineering, history, politics, economics, agriculture and animals. He had an intricate knowledge of the intricacies of aircraft